

also required to provide an annual report to their shareholders that discloses how the fund is being operated, its main goals, and its financial state.

These annual reports are available publicly and can be found on the company or fund's website or with a quick Google search. The U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission website (<https://www.sec.gov/edgar/searchedgar/companysearch.html>) also allows you to access the annual report filings for pretty much any company that is publicly available. Reviewing a company's or fund's annual report, especially its financials, can help you get a good idea of what the company or fund is about and in turn help you make informed investing decisions.

Some more in-depth factors that you may be interested in if you want to geek out when doing your research for a company's stock would include:

- Whether the company owes more than it owns
- Whether the company is reporting profits, or losses (and why)
- Whether they're earning money from their sales and operations, as opposed to having money coming in mostly due to borrowing activities (aka debt)

All of this information can typically be found in the company's publicly available financial reports.

2. The company or fund's historical performance

Looking at historical trends can provide you with important information on how a stock or fund has performed year over year. Essentially, you want to make sure the investment is consistently performing well on average while taking historical economic climates into consideration. For example, the 2008 stock market crash had a hard impact on almost all investments, but some fared better than others. Here are two examples of historical performance charts that are publicly available using an online investment research tool. These two images show the historical performance of Coca-Cola (Symbol: KO) and Vanguard's Total Stock Market Index Fund (Symbol: VTSAX):